bombing of the US embassy in Nairobi. Just after we prepared the leaks, Ethiopia invaded Somalia, with US assistance. We continued to follow the situation, offering analysis, comment and other leaked information where we could. Even if the document was a fake, perhaps prepared by Chinese sources, it still raised important questions and showed how the disclosure of secret documents could enhance our understanding of complex political situations. It seemed like a good first move for a young website like WikiLeaks.

We're so used to the pieties of the Western media – to say nothing of the rampant censorship in vast portions of the East – that we forget how many countries have a great hunger among their people for free publishing and for the exposure of abuses. We got a quick response from many areas of the world, not all reliable, not all helpful, but people were tuning in to what we were doing. From the start, of course, being a whistleblowing website, as they call us, certain people were keen to blow the whistle on us and that hasn't changed. My response was, 'Fair enough. We should eat our own dog food and see how it tastes.' We were a group of committed, idealistic people who were trying to get something done. We could take what flak was on offer, but our basic position was strong and ethical, and I couldn't see what rubbish could be thrown at us. I suppose I hadn't prepared myself for the personal smears, or, to any great degree, the smearing of the whole organisation by people who decided to hate us. Some mad individuals thought we were working for the CIA.

But we pressed on. I tried to bring in friends, but friendship, in my experience, will only buy you about nine hours of free labour. And there was an unbelievable amount of work. I had worked through the ideas over many years, but the programming and the logistics had to be done quickly and effectively. I was going from Kenya to Tanzania to Cairo, building the site all the way, and that's when I really began to live out of a small rucksack. I must say I had never been one for belongings. I didn't have many clothes. I ate whatever was going. I spent or gave away whatever money I had almost instantly. It was galling, watching so many of the bright computer nerds of my generation become millionaires, not because I wanted the money but because I could've used their help. But during these itinerant years that began WikiLeaks, I realised, quite gradually, that I had need of very little material stuff at all. I had a bag of socks and underwear, and a bigger bag of laptops and cables.